Colossians 3:18–4:1 — Leader / Learner Guide

The Relationships of the New Man · a one-page guide for leaders and learners

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians · TheGospelVault.com · @iJohn.316 (Instagram)

① Big Idea and Context

Big idea: The new self lives out its new life at home and at work, where every role is fulfilled as service to the Lord Christ, who rewards faithfulness and judges without partiality.

After the "put on" passage (3:12–17), Paul applies the Word-filled life to the household, paralleling Ephesians 5:22–6:9. He addresses each member directly, beginning with those under authority.

- **Marriage:** wives submit as fitting in the Lord; husbands love and are not embittered.
- **Family:** children obey; fathers do not exasperate.
- **Work:** servants work heartily for the Lord; masters give justice and fairness.

② Every Relationship Before the Lord — Three Anchor Verses

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
3:18–19	*"be subject … as is fitting in the Lord … love your wives and do not be embittered"*	Order without inferiority; authority exercised in love.
3:23–24	*"do your work heartily, as for the Lord … you will receive the reward of the inheritance"*	Ordinary work is service to Christ and will be rewarded.
4:1	*"you too have a Master in heaven"*	Every master is also a servant accountable to the Lord.

Power, purpose, pattern: the Spirit, God's glory, and Christ; moral philosophy alone is a train without an engine.
Inheritance: every believer has one by grace; there is also an inheritance as reward (Dillow).

③ Teaching Flow

1. **Wives (3:18)** — Rank under your own husband; fitting by creation and Godhead order.
2. **Husbands (3:19)** — Agapē love; no bitterness; mutual obligation.
3. **Children and fathers (3:20–21)** — Obey, pleasing the Lord; do not exasperate.
4. **Servants (3:22–25)** — No eye-service; heartily for the Lord; reward and impartial justice.
5. **Masters (4:1)** — Justice and fairness; a Master in heaven.

④ Clarify While Teaching

- **Abuse:** submission never requires a wife to accept abuse or to sin; say this plainly.
- **Slavery:** Paul did not endorse slavery; explain the principles that undermined it, and apply the text to employees and employers.
- **"Children … in all things":** minors at home; limited by obedience to God.
- **Inheritance as reward:** a Free Grace reading (Dillow); Reformed readers usually take the inheritance as final salvation given to all true believers. v.25 concerns believers' recompense, not loss of eternal life.

⑤ Discussion and Close

1. In which of your relationships is it hardest to live as the new self?
2. How does 1 Corinthians 11:3 show that submission does not mean inferiority?
3. How should "as for the Lord" change the way you approach your work this week?

Close: Next, Paul turns to prayer and witness: "Devote yourselves to prayer … conduct yourselves with wisdom toward outsiders" (4:2–6). "It is the Lord Christ whom you serve."

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